

ANI

The IPL's fairy tales continue to amaze. This year it was a 14-year-old who walked in, took guard, and hit the first ball he faced in the IPL for a six. By the end of his third match, Vaibhav Suryavanshi had done enough to show that this was no flash in the pan. Just ask Gujarat Titans' pace spearhead Mohammed Siraj who likely didn't expect the cherubic man-child to wreak such havoc. But one shot, standing inches outside the leg stump, and sending a good-length delivery soaring over the off-side boundary, cleaved away with an inside out swing of the bat, showed his ominous intent. By the end of it, the schoolboy prodigy had delivered an unforgettable performance—101 off 38 balls, the fastest century by an Indian in IPL history. Records were tumbling at every turn; he was already the youngest debutant at 14 years and 23 days, and by the end of the tournament he would also be the Super Striker of the Season.

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VAIBHAV SURYAVANSHI, 14
Rajasthan Royals

MATCHES: 7 RUNS: 252
AVERAGE: 36.00 STRIKE RATE: 206.5

VIPRAJ NIGAM, 20
Delhi Capitals

MATCHES: 14 RUNS: 142 AVG: 20.3
STRIKE RATE: 179.7
(BOWLING) ECONOMY: 9.1 WKTS: 11

Picked up by Delhi Capitals for Rs 50 lakh, Vipraj Nigam found himself playing his debut IPL match against his home team, the Lucknow Super Giants. Nigam had shown promise with his performances at the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy last year, prompting Delhi to close the deal with him. Beginning as a batsman who could also bowl leg spin, he's evolved as an all-rounder. And he earned his spurs in the first match itself. Delhi was struggling at 65/5 chasing LSG's score of 210 when Nigam came in and scored a quickfire 39 off 15 balls. Delhi won the match by one wicket. Nigam has also done enough with the ball, picking up prize scalps like Kohli, Rohit Sharma and the Pandya brothers, among others. Nigam's first season has gone smashingly well, and he's still only 20. —Rahul Noronha

